

# Dental health

Dentistry wasn't recognized as a separate form of medicine until the early 18th century, when the French surgeon Pierre Fauchard wrote an influential book about caring for and treating teeth. Since then, scientists have made many advances in dental technology, helping to keep our teeth clean, healthy, and looking their best.

## THE DENTIST'S CHAIR

The American dentist Milton Hanchett invented the first adjustable dentist's chair in 1848. It had a headrest, a back that could be tilted, and a seat that could be moved up and down. Another American dentist, Basil Manly Wilkerson, came up with the first hydraulic chair, in 1877, which could be raised and lowered using a pedal.



## BRUSHING TEETH

The oldest known toothbrush was found in China and dates back to c. 750 CE. It has a brush made of pig bristles (thick hair) attached to a bone handle. Modern toothbrushes have nylon bristles attached to a plastic handle. The above image shows British children brushing their teeth in around 1920.

Dentures made from hippopotamus teeth, c.1795



The two large front teeth are recycled human teeth.

## FALSE TEETH

Dentures (false teeth)—made from both human and animal teeth—have been around since prehistoric times. As people ate more sugar in the 18th century and teeth rotted, the demand for dentures grew. Making dentures from an artificial material—porcelain—was pioneered by the Frenchman Alexis Duchâteau in 1774, and improved then patented in the UK in 1791 by the French dentist Nicholas Dubois de Chémont. Modern dentures are usually made of plastic.



Headrest

Curved leather seat for patient's comfort

Pedal for adjusting the height of the chair

High-tech hydraulic chair, c.1925